



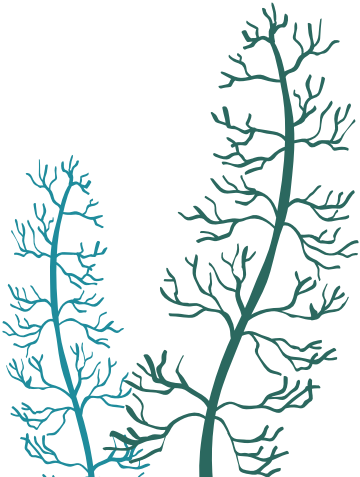
Food and Agriculture
Organization of the
United Nations



GUIDELINES for SUSTAINABLE AQUACULTURE



Communications handbook and toolkit



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SUSTAINABLE AQUACULTURE

Communications handbook and toolkit

Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
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Contents

1. Purpose and how to use this handbook.....	4
2. Communicating the Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture.....	5
3. Core narrative and global key messages.....	6
4. Communication products and tools.....	8
4.1 Communication assets and digital resources.....	8
4.1.1 Trello board and social media assets.....	8
4.1.2 Website.....	8
4.1.3 Case studies.....	9
4.2 Policy brief.....	10
4.3 Factsheet.....	10
5. Guidance for stakeholder groups.....	11
5.1 Governments, public institutions and regional fishery management organizations.....	11
5.22 The private sector, industry organizations and certification bodies.....	12
5.33 Non-governmental organizations, civil society and community-based organizations.....	12
5.4 Academia, research institutions and the scientific community.....	13
Annex I – Targeted key messages for stakeholders.....	14



1. Purpose and how to use this handbook

The Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture (GSA) were adopted by the FAO Committee on Fisheries (COFI) in July 2024.

They provide a shared vision and a set of principles, practices and recommendations that countries can implement to transform their aquaculture sectors in line with the 2030 Agenda, the [FAO Blue Transformation Roadmap 2022–2030](#) and the [2021 COFI Declaration](#). The GSA serve as a roadmap to foster good governance, science-based decision-making, effective management and inclusive, environmentally responsible value chains based on respect for human rights. Their ultimate goal is to ensure that sustainable aquaculture delivers food security and nutrition, equitable livelihoods, restored ecosystems and climate resilience.

Communicating the GSA is vital to their implementation. Clear, consistent and effective communication helps translate the Guidelines into practice and support their positive impact, while strengthening public understanding and acceptance of the aquaculture sector.

Under the European Union-funded project “*Supporting a Blue Transformation: Implementation of the Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture and Empowerment of Small-scale Fisheries Actors*”, FAO has worked in close collaboration with Members and stakeholders to mainstream the GSA into global, regional and national policies and strategic frameworks.

This handbook is part of that effort. It provides practical tools, messages and resources to help governments, international organizations, civil society and the private sector communicate the GSA in a coherent, consistent and effective way.



2. Communicating the Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture

The GSA represent the collective will and vision of FAO Members and provide a shared reference framework for non-FAO stakeholders in decision-making, policy reform and sector development. They contribute to a sustainable intensification and expansion of the sector that can meet global demand for aquatic foods while distributing benefits equitably, in line with the FAO Blue Transformation Roadmap.

Effective communication of the GSA is key to their uptake and implementation across different contexts and stakeholder groups. Communication efforts should aim to:

- > **inform** stakeholders about how the GSA can support their commitments, goals and mandates;
- > **mainstream** the GSA in governance mechanisms at local, national and regional levels so that they can be used to inform updates and amendments and to inspire new or supplementary policies, legislative and regulatory frameworks, and better management practices;
- > **communicate** to consumers, civil society and the media that sustainable aquaculture is achievable and worth supporting, strengthening public acceptance of aquaculture products and the sector's social license to operate;
- > **address concerns**, recognizing that aquaculture may face environmental challenges, animal welfare criticism, social license constraints, limited consumer acceptance and public misperceptions. Effective communication can help respond with transparent, evidence-based information and context-sensitive engagement, build trust and social acceptance, support informed dialogue and reinforce the credibility of both the GSA and the actors promoting their implementation.



3. Core narrative and global key messages

The following key messages provide a shared narrative to communicate the GSA. They can be used across all groups, sectors and channels and adapted to different contexts, audiences and objectives.

Vision

The GSA envision an environmentally, socially and economically sustainable aquaculture sector that contributes to a world free from hunger and to the equitable improvement of living standards across the value chain, including the poorest.

Alignment

The GSA underpin FAO's work in aquaculture and direct the development of the sector in line with global commitments and frameworks.

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The GSA outline priorities and actions needed to advance aquaculture as a global, sustainable and competitive food production sector in line with the SDGs.

Consensus

The GSA represent a milestone and collective achievement by FAO and its Members, underscoring the global recognition of the importance of aquaculture.

Food security and nutrition

The GSA promote responsible aquaculture that meets the increasing demand for safe, healthy, accessible and affordable aquatic foods.



Environment

The GSA recognize that aquaculture development must improve its environmental performance for the sake of current and future generations.

Practices

The GSA encourage more productive, efficient, resilient, climate-smart and socially and environmentally responsible aquatic food systems.

Future

The GSA provide guidance for future development such that the aquaculture sector evolves in economically, socially and environmentally sustainable ways.

Targeted key messages to support the specific needs of different stakeholder groups can be found in Annex I.

The Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture provide a shared vision and roadmap to transform aquaculture through good governance, science-based decision-making and responsible practices.





4. Communication products and tools

This section describes the main communication tools and products developed to support the dissemination of the GSA and to raise awareness of their implementation across different audiences and stakeholder groups.

4.1 Communication assets and digital resources

4.1.1 Trello board and social media assets

The [GSA Trello board](#) provides a curated collection of communication materials, including social media cards, key messages, videos, factsheets, stories and a photo collection organized by themes and regions from around the world.

The materials include an animated video that presents the purpose and relevance of the GSA through engaging and inclusive visuals. It can be shared on social media and screened at stakeholder events.

The Trello board can be used as a centralized source of ready-to-use communication assets. Governments, organizations and partners can use these materials to support their own outreach activities, campaigns, policy communication and public engagement on aquaculture, while ensuring consistency and coherence with the GSA narrative.

4.1.2 Website

The [GSA website](#) serves as a communications and knowledge management hub. It features case studies and publications, stories and videos, supporting materials and links to relevant resources.

The website includes a [section](#) with e-learning courses on topics like biosecurity, breeding and genetics, co-management and climate change adaptation related to sustainable aquaculture. New relevant courses are added as they become available.



[Stories](#) published on the website illustrate how sustainable aquaculture works in practice, by translating the principles and recommendations of the GSA into concrete examples. Through human-interest narratives they show how the GSA are applied in different contexts across countries and stakeholder groups. These stories are designed to engage the media and the general public by showing the viability and the benefits of sustainable aquaculture.

The website also documents FAO activities and events related to the GSA and is regularly updated with new content.

By combining a blend of reference materials, storytelling and updates on processes and activities, the website serves experts and aquaculture stakeholders and practitioners while remaining accessible and engaging for a broader public and the media.

4.1.3 Case studies

A dedicated section of the website gathers [case studies](#) illustrating how the GSA can be applied on the ground. They provide country-level examples of good practices, innovations and enabling policy approaches, linked to specific sections of the GSA.

FAO encourages Members and partners to submit additional case studies, noting that all case studies must be endorsed by the competent national authority. FAO provides support to finalize them for publication on the GSA website, including relevant templates.

Proposals for case studies and requests for information can be directed to GSA@fao.org.



4.2 Policy brief

The policy brief provides a concise, actionable entry point to the GSA. It summarizes their key principles, recommendations and priority actions and is aimed at expert audiences.

It is designed to support informed decision-making and can be used as a background document for government consultations, expert discussions and policy dialogues at all levels.

It is available on the GSA website.

4.3 Factsheet

[The Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture at a glance](#) factsheet is a quick and handy reference tool that provides an overview of the GSA. It aims to be accessible to all stakeholders, from policymakers to practitioners to civil society.

It can be used to support campaigns and outreach activities that leverage the GSA, and as a complement to the GSA policy brief. Additional factsheets on specific aspects of sustainable aquaculture are available on the GSA website.



5. Guidance for stakeholder groups

The GSA are addressed to a wide range of stakeholders involved in policymaking, production, and research across the aquaculture sector. Their effective implementation depends on the ability of these actors to understand, adapt and communicate the GSA within their respective contexts and mandates. The key messages, narrative and practical tools this handbook provides can be used to reach out to different audiences, communication channels and policy environments.

Different stakeholder groups play distinct but complementary roles in communicating the GSA. The following section presents ideas on how each group can use this handbook and its tools.

5.1 Governments, public institutions and regional fishery management organizations

Governments, public institutions and regional fishery management organizations with aquaculture mandates play a key role in the implementation of the GSA. They are responsible for integrating the Guidelines into regional and national strategies and regulatory frameworks.

This handbook can support governments, public institutions and regional fishery management organizations to:

- mainstream the GSA into national and regional development and sectoral narratives;
- communicate the relevance of the GSA to policymakers, technical staff and political leadership;
- leverage the GSA to achieve regional consensus and cooperation on aspects including biodiversity conservation, biosecurity, climate change, spatial planning and fair trade.

Key tools: policy brief, factsheet, case studies, web resources



5.2 The private sector, industry organizations and certification bodies

The private sector and certification bodies are essential to translating the GSA into responsible practices. These industry actors are also important communicators for consumers, investors and policymakers.

This handbook can support the private sector and certification bodies to:

- align corporate strategies and sustainability commitments with GSA principles;
- communicate responsible industry practices to markets and consumers;
- strengthen the credibility of sustainability claims.

Key tools: factsheet, case studies, web resources

5.3 Non-governmental organizations, civil society.3 Non-govand community-based organizationsy

These stakeholders play an important role in communicating the GSA to their networks and constituencies as well as to policy and decision makers, in support of sustainable and responsible practices.

This handbook can support NGOs, civil society and community-based organizations to:

- use the GSA to frame their advocacy and outreach efforts;
- communicate the relevance of the GSA to communities, practitioners and decision makers;
- leverage the GSA to empower communities, small-scale farmers, women, youth and Indigenous Peoples.

Key tools: factsheet, stories, videos, social media and web resources



5.4 Academia, research institutions and the scientific community

This sector is a driver of innovation in aquaculture and an essential partner in communicating the GSA as a framework that can inform scientific work and research. This is especially relevant to the younger generations who are the creative thinkers and leaders of tomorrow.

This handbook can support academia, research institutions and the scientific community to:

- frame research around aspects that need improvement, such as breeding and genetics, the bioeconomy, climate change adaptation and mitigation, and sustainable fish feed;
- leverage the GSA to communicate their findings within the science-to-policy nexus;
- disseminate research findings linked to sustainable aquaculture.

Key tools: policy brief, factsheet, web resources.

Effective communication by governments, industry, civil society and other stakeholders is vital to improving public understanding and perception of responsible and sustainable aquaculture. When the GSA are communicated clearly, consistently and credibly across policies, practices and narratives, they can help build trust within the media and the wider public. This, in turn, strengthens awareness of the viability and benefits of sustainable aquaculture, fostering broader support for the sector.

ANNEX I

Targeted key messages for stakeholders



The GSA aim to ensure that sustainable aquaculture delivers food security and nutrition, equitable livelihoods, restored ecosystems and climate resilience.



The following sets of key messages have been developed to support different stakeholder groups in their communications and outreach efforts.

Stakeholder group:

FAO Members, policy and decision makers, regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks, donors, development partners, UN agencies

Handbook goal:

The GSA underpin FAO's work in aquaculture and direct the development of the guidance, tools and examples to support the mainstreaming of the GSA into sustainable aquaculture policies and regional coordination mechanisms, alignment with the SDGs, and resource mobilization efforts.

KEY MESSAGES



Sustainable aquaculture expansion and intensification can help meet growing global demand for aquatic foods and contribute to food security and poverty alleviation while protecting aquatic ecosystems and biodiversity.

The GSA are a milestone and collective achievement by FAO and its Members in recognition of the need to cooperate towards the 2030 Agenda and its SDGs.

All FAO work in the aquaculture sector is in line with the GSA, which reflect the collective and agreed vision of Members.

The GSA provide policy and decision makers with recommendations and normative guidance to formulate and implement policies, strategies, management plans and enabling legal and institutional frameworks to drive the Blue Transformation of their aquaculture sectors.

The GSA are a tool to implement the FAO Code of Conduct for Responsible Fisheries.



The GSA can be used to achieve national targets for economically, socially and environmentally sustainable development in line with the SDGs and the 2030 Agenda, thereby generating trust in government vision and leadership.

Policy and decision makers can use the GSA to ensure their aquaculture sectors make key contributions to food security and nutrition, help buffer the impacts of climate change and generate community resilience, decent employment, and poverty alleviation.

Policy and decision makers can use the GSA to foster responsible and sustainable aquaculture as a driver of employment, economic growth, social and economic development, environmental recovery and technological innovation.

The GSA provide a framework for regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks to deliver their mandates and agendas more effectively.

Regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks can use the GSA to increase their participation in decision-making by formulating advice and/or legally binding management measures.

The GSA support regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks by offering guidance to establish implementation and monitoring mechanisms for sustainable aquaculture policy frameworks and strategies.

Regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks can use the GSA to align their mission with the 2030 Agenda and its SDGs and the FAO Blue Transformation Roadmap.

The GSA support regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks to achieve their broader targets such as regional economic integration and interconnectivity in sustainable development.

The GSA can help regional fisheries management organizations, advisory bodies and regional aquaculture networks to bolster international cooperation and dialogue with FAO, its partners and networks in the sustainable aquaculture sector.

The GSA support regional economic organizations in achieving their own targets and mandates by providing recommendations and normative guidance for the formulation and implementation of policies, strategies, plans as well as enabling legal and institutional frameworks for economic growth in the aquaculture sector.



Regional economic organizations can leverage the GSA to promote sustainable economic development and prosperity, serving both the community and the region, in line with the 2030 Agenda and its SDGs.

By using the GSA, regional economic organizations can increase trust in their vision and work and enhance their dialogue with other relevant stakeholders in the aquaculture sector.

Promoting and implementing the GSA will benefit regions by leveraging responsible aquaculture as a driver of sustainable economic development, and regional economic organizations can play a key role in supporting this process.

Regional economic organizations can use the GSA as a lens to assess investment and business opportunities, including through public-private partnerships, to make aquaculture a generator of food security and nutrition and prosperity while also protecting the environment.

Many donor and development organization targets are in line with the GSA, including:

- sustainable economic development: the growth of the aquaculture sector offers new business opportunities, generates income and contributes to national and local economies;
- improved quality of life: food security, better health through nutrition, and inclusive livelihoods that empower women and youth;
- environment: responsible practices and science-based decision-making contribute to increased adaptability and climate resilience, improved water quality, biodiversity conservation and restored ecosystems;
- SDGs: achieving overall sustainable development in line with the 2030 Agenda.

The GSA support the work of donors and development organizations by:

- providing guidance to formulate and implement strategies for sustainable aquatic food systems;
- enhancing trust in their work and contributing to their positive image through their support for projects for the greater good.

Stakeholder group:

Industry, farmers and producers, certification bodies

Handbook goal:

Support to adopt and promote sustainable aquaculture practices in line with the GSA and the SDGs, maintain and improve industry standards, access guidance and communicate compliance and innovation across the value chain.

KEY MESSAGES



Being in line with the GSA can increase the industry's social license to operate, dispel public misperceptions and foster consumer confidence.

Being in line with GSA will enable farmers and producers to qualify for international certifications, increasing their competitiveness on the market, their livelihoods and their economic wellbeing.

Farmers and producers can use the GSA to improve their working conditions and quality of life.

Being in line with the GSA will attract responsible private investments, leading to technological innovations and improved infrastructure for climate-smart, resilient, profitable, efficient and sustainable aquaculture systems.

Producers can leverage the GSA to advocate for more public investment in their sector and technical and financial support from donors and development partners, as well as to represent their interests in decision-making venues.

Integrating GSA criteria in product certifications will lend them even more credibility.



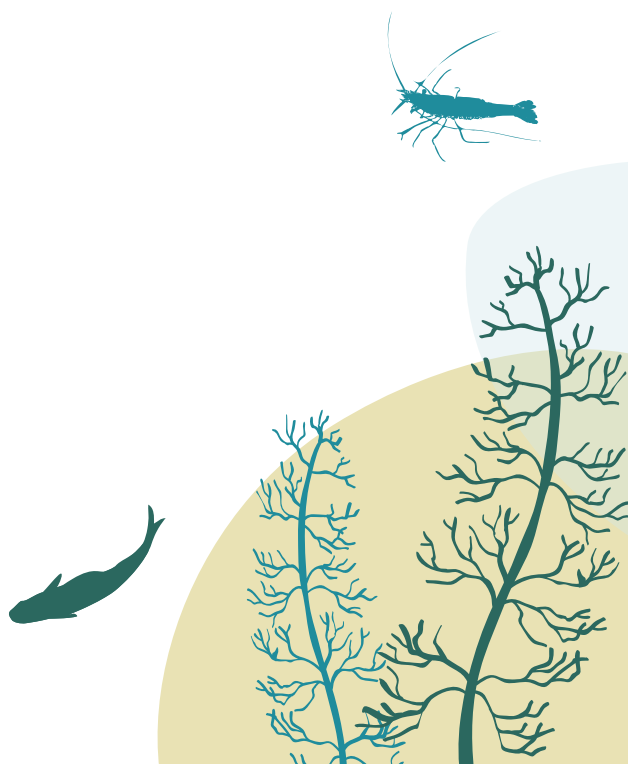
The GSA promote environmental sustainability and an ecosystem approach to aquaculture that balances conservation with responsible management and use of biodiversity, water, and other natural resources.

The GSA promote socially responsible aquaculture based on fair labour practices, workplace safety, gender equity and equality, participatory approaches, community engagement and respect for human rights.

The GSA call for transparency and traceability throughout aquaculture value chains, and certifications in line with the GSA will help drive compliance and channel economic rewards and incentives to responsible farmers, producers and suppliers.

Applying GSA criteria can benefit the work of aquaculture certification bodies by:

- > offering guidance to elaborate further certification criteria;
- > increasing consumer confidence by establishing them as even more trustworthy, credible institutions.





Stakeholder group:

Academia, research institutions and the scientific community

Handbook goal:

Provide examples of the GSA in practice, success stories and lessons learned, insights on research topics and innovation needed, tools to advocate for the integration of evidence-based solutions into policy and practice.



KEY MESSAGES

Researchers play a vital role in generating scientific evidence to support informed policy and decision-making in line with the GSA.

Researchers are key to drive scientific innovation in line with the GSA: they are needed to develop new protocols, technologies and solutions, for example in environmental risk mitigation, climate change adaptation, disaster recovery, and improved farming and husbandry techniques.

Working on topics linked to the GSA and their implementation can benefit academia and researchers by:

- offering access to the FAO network of experts, partners and platforms for peer-to-peer exchange;
- channelling their findings to inform development projects, strategies and policymaking;
- increasing their funding opportunities because the GSA and their implementation are of global relevance;
- making them active contributors to social wellbeing, environmental stewardship, and the achievement of the 2030 Agenda and its SDGs.



Stakeholder group:

NGOs, civil society and community-based organizations

Handbook goal:

Provide reference documents and messaging to advocate for sustainable aquaculture practices in line with the GSA, raise awareness among different stakeholders and support community-based initiatives and engagement. Accessible information and examples from the field through storytelling to build awareness, trust, social acceptance and support for sustainable aquaculture, while driving demand for responsibly produced aquatic foods.

KEY MESSAGES



The GSA recognize the need to make aquaculture environmentally responsible and sustainable for the sake of current and future generations.

The GSA promote the principles of environmental stewardship and an ecosystem approach for the conservation and sustainable use of precious natural resources, including biodiversity, water and land.

The GSA promote many environmentally friendly practices, including restorative aquaculture that can bring degraded ecosystems back to health, circular and integrated models that eliminate the need for chemical fertilizers in agriculture, aquaponics, and ecological aquaculture.

When practiced in line with the GSA, aquaculture...

- is an efficient way to produce highly nutritious food with less carbon, less water, and less waste than land-based farming;
- can help restock depleted wild species and provide habitat and refuge for both terrestrial and aquatic biodiversity.



Aquaculture of certain species, when practiced in line with the GSA, can help address water quality degradation, habitat loss, and climate pressures.

The GSA seek to promote animal health and wellbeing; for organizations that are contrary to aquaculture due to animal welfare concerns, the GSA still represent an improvement over the status quo.

The GSA promote participatory approaches that involve local communities and civil society; they can be used to advocate for reform, including for animal welfare.

The GSA are in line with the 2030 Agenda and its SDGs.

The adoption of the GSA is a signal of a global political will to improve, strengthen, nurture and support aquaculture in recognition of its vital role in food security and nutrition, poverty alleviation and sustainable economic development, and environmental stewardship.

The GSA provide global guidance for policymakers and practitioners on how to achieve sustainable aquaculture that delivers economic, environmental and social benefits for the good of present and future generations.

Aquaculture NGOs can leverage the GSA to drive their advocacy and outreach efforts and to frame their discourse when engaging with policymakers, donors, civil society, consumers, industry, academia and the private sector.

The GSA bring unity and a shared vision, and aquaculture NGOs can use them to rally efforts behind common goals such as environmental stewardship, fair trade and decent work, equitable livelihoods, community empowerment and gender equality, biosecurity and animal welfare, and scientific and technological innovation for climate-smart, resilient and productive aquatic farming systems.

The GSA provide clear guidance to produce aquatic foods in ways that are environmentally sustainable, socially responsible, and safe for consumers.

Supporting aquaculture aligned with the GSA contributes to equitable livelihoods, fair trade and responsible practices.

The GSA help ensure that farmed aquatic products are produced with respect for animal welfare, environmental stewardship, and ethical practices.

By choosing products from sustainable aquaculture, consumers can support practices that promote decent work and fair trade, protect ecosystems, and foster climate-smart aquatic food systems.

Public awareness and understanding of the GSA strengthen the sector's social license to operate and encourage transparency, accountability, and trust between governments, producers and consumers.

Sustainable aquaculture is possible and is already being practiced in many forms around the world.

Clear and consistent communication is vital to translate the Guidelines into practice, strengthen their impact, and build public understanding and acceptance of aquaculture.



Communicating the Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture (GSA) is vital to their implementation. Clear and consistent communication helps translate the GSA into practice, strengthen their impact, and build public understanding and acceptance of the aquaculture sector. Under the European Union-funded project “Supporting a Blue Transformation: Implementation of the Guidelines for Sustainable Aquaculture”, FAO has worked with Members and stakeholders to integrate the GSA into policies and strategies at all levels. This handbook supports that effort by providing practical tools and messages to help key actors communicate the GSA effectively.

**For questions or further information,
please contact the GSA Team at GSA@fao.org.**



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